This ties in with Jha's view that even though ancient Indian monarchs sought to become chakravartin (supreme ruler dispensing justice and maintaining peace), the boundaries of his rule were limited to the geographically and culturally defined region of the subcontinent.[28] Indians did not like exercising power beyond their shores and could not philosophically accept others occupying their land or ruling over them. When Nehru said, 'India's foreign policy is grounded in the ancient tradition and culture of this country',[29] he also suggested that India's opposition to Western imperialism could be traced back to the ancient Indian world view.

The Chola Empire (300 BC–AD 1279) was a notable exception to India's eschewing overseas entanglements. It was the only Indian empire that sought not only trade ties with other civilizations but a political presence beyond India's geographical boundaries. The Cholas' willing militarism and activist external policy enabled this South Indian dynasty to last from the third century BC to the thirteenth century AD. Initially the Cholas only extended their political and cultural influence into present-day Sri Lanka. In doing so they followed the path of other south Indian dynasties like the Pandyas (sixth century BC to twelfth century AD) and the Pallavas (third to ninth century AD), who saw the island just south of India's coast as a natural extension of India rather than as imperial expansion. During the eleventh century AD, however, the Cholas invaded the Sri Vijaya Empire in present-day Indonesia, breaking from the tradition of isolationism and acting as an activist great power in south-East Asia.

Historians disagree on the reasons for Chola expansion into South-East Asia and the extent of their subsequent political influence in that region. For some, the reason was the simple desire to control trade routes while others discern aspirations for political control similar to those of imperialist nations. According to some historians, the Chola invasion was simply a one-off military raid as they did not have the capacity to control a region so